CRICKET

TRUE GRIT

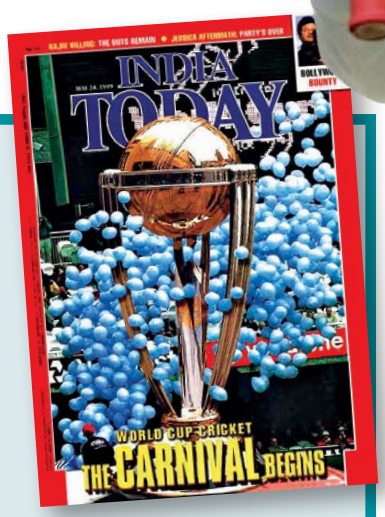
The golden team forged under Ganguly's captaincy fought opponents on green pitches, and fought them on dusty bowls. Unlike past greats, it never surrendered easily

SOURAV GANGULY, DRAVID AND LAXMAN ARRIVED IN 1996; BHAJJI IN 1998, SEHWAG IN 2001: A GENERATION THAT CHANGED INDIAN CRICKET, WITH SACHIN AND KUMBLE



Great sporting teams are born under a lucky star—old masters and new sparks come together for a few years to make magic on the field of play. It was clear in the mid-'90s that barring Azharuddin just past his zenith, Sachin Tendulkar settling in as a batting great, and Anil Kumble and Javagal Srinath as the trusted spin-pace duo, a transfusion of blood was needed. The revelation came in June 1996, at Lord's—the debut of Sourav Ganguly, one with Gower-ish grace, and Rahul Dravid, blessed with poise and a flawless all-round game. Later that year arrived the other exponent of willowy elasticity—V.V.S. Laxman. In 2000-2001, the last pieces of the jigsaw arrived in the simple explosiveness of Virender Sehwag and the controlled seam bowling of Zaheer Khan.

Together, the batsmen presented the full-



The Carnival Begins
May 24, 1999

"Cricket in England has become a depressant, the refuge of the old and weary. When India played a practice match at Nottinghamshire, 700-odd people and a lost dog showed up. The grounds are wondrous but the sound of leather against willow is inevitably accompanied by a symphony of snoring. Thank the Lord for the subcontinent, for like some subterranean cult it is the Indians, the Pakistanis, the Sri Lankans and the Bangladeshis who are stoking the passions of this Cup. The heart of the game has crossed continents."

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